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Revisiting OE *holm-wudu* in *The Dream of the Rood*: The Salvific Ship and the Name of Mary

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ABSTRACT
This article supports retaining the manuscript reading *holm-wudu* in *The Dream of the Rood* 91a, and argues that the poet highlights a parallel between the Cross and Mary in 90–4 to emphasise the theme of spiritual voyage towards salvation. Both the Cross and Mary have been closely associated with Christian ship-symbolism and life-voyage motif in patristic and exegetical works known in the early medieval period. The unique poetic compound *holm-wudu* ("sea-wood"), which is often emended to *holt-wudu* ("forest-wood"), plays a vital part in the establishment of ship-symbolism in the poem. Examining the etymological meaning of Mary as *stella maris* ("star of the sea"), the nautical diction in the poem, and other extant Old English "sea-wood" compounds in the corpus, this article contends that the poet's emphasis on ship-symbolism renders the suggested emendation both superfluous and misleading.

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The Dream of the Rood; Old English poetry; Virgin Mary; ship symbolism; spiritual voyage; paronomasia

The Dream of the Rood is perhaps among the earliest and certainly one of the most celebrated poems in the Old English corpus.[1] The poem is undoubtedly an artistically-profound and well-crafted work written by a "highly skilled and apparently widely regarded poet".[2] With a rich display of Cross-symbolism throughout its narrative, the poem highlights the importance of the worship of the Cross in early medieval England.[3] However, the meaning and word-form of the first element in the *-wudu* compound in 91a remain controversial. Here the manuscript clearly reads *holm-wudu* (*holm* "sea", *wudu* "wood"), with this unique maritime compound split across a line-break.[4] The contested reading occurs in the passage where the Cross is compared with the Virgin Mary. The text as preserved in the Vercelli Book reads:

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[1]On an early date for the poem based on poetic archaism and the influence of earlier liturgical texts, see, Ó Carragáin, "Vision Transfigured into Prayer," 308, 316, and 331.
[2]Orchard, "Cross-References," 226.
[3]Bestul, "Continental Sources," 119. For further reference, see Stevens, *The Cross in the Life and Literature*, esp. 63–76.
[4]The statistics of word-frequency and definitions of individual words in this article are generally based on the *DOE* and its corpus, Orchard's *Word-hord*, and *B-T*.

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Hwæt mē þā geweorðode wuldres Ealdor
ofer holm-wudu, heofon-rīces weard.
swylce swā hē his mōdor ēac, Mārian sylfe,
æl-mihtig God for ealle menn
geweorðode ofer eall wīfa cynn! (90–4)[5]

(Listen! The Lord of Glory then honoured me above the wood-of-the-sea, the guardian of the heavenly-kingdom, just as he, Almighty God, also honoured his mother, Mary herself, over all women, in front of all people!)

The poet uses the same verb *geweorþigan* ("to honour") twice to pair the personified Cross with Mary. Alongside the parallel between God honouring the Cross and God honouring Mary, there are two contrasts, respectively revering the personified Cross (*mē*) above all *holm-wudu*, and Mary (*Mārian*) above all women (*eall wīfa cynn*). While the identification of Mary as a woman is straightforward, what is obscure and perplexing is the image of the Cross above all *holm-wudu*.

The compound *holm-wudu* is inconsistently defined in *B-T*, which explains *holm-wudu* as "wood growing on a hill", evidently based on early Middle English *holm* ("hill"), whereas *DOE* gives three possible meanings: "tree of the meadow", emendation to *holt-wudu* ("forest-wood", "tree of the forest"), and an alternative meaning of "sea-wood", "ship".[6] The obvious doubts of lexicographers over the meaning of *holm-wudu* indicates both a discrepancy of understanding and a need for further research.

From the 1850s to the present, extensive commentary on *holm-wudu* has produced no consensus. Since J. M. Kemble and C. W. M. Grein, many editors and commentators of *The Dream of the Rood* have proposed that the first element *holm* ("sea", "ocean") should be replaced by *holt* ("wood", "grove") or *helm* ("protection", "protector"), and that the manuscript form *holm-wudu* should have been a scribal error.[7] Some have suggested an emendation to *holt-wudu* for varied reasons. In terms of word frequency, *holt-wudu* is securely attested in *Beowulf* 1369b and 2340a and *The Phoenix* 171b, whilst *holm-wudu* is unique to *The Dream of the Rood*.[8] Concerning the immediate narrative context, the Holy Cross is cut down from its roots at the edge of the forest (28–30a), and there are no other explicit maritime elements in the poem.[9] Only a few scholars have argued in favour of retaining the manuscript form *holm-wudu*.[10] Amongst them, some tend to move away from the strictly nautical theme espoused by this article,

[5]The text of *The Dream of the Rood* cited in this article is taken from Clayton's *Old English Poems*. The diacritics of vowels in Old English words are added to the quotations, while other editorial marks in modern editions are removed. All translations provided in this article are my own.

[6]*B-T*, **s.v.** "*holm-wudu*"; *DOE*, **s.v.** "*holm-wudu*". The *DOE* gives: "*i.e.*, the Cross transports the faithful across the 'sea' of this life (*cf. brim-*, *flōd-*, *sǣ-*, *sund-wudu*)". Similarly, *Word-hord* provides "sea-wood; ship; the Cross, interpreted as a ship", but also points to an existing poetic compound *holt-wudu* ("forest-wood").The earliest occurrence of early Middle English *holm* is attested in Laȝamon's alliterative poem *Brut* 10334 and 10409. See further, Brook and Leslie, eds., *Laȝamon*, II, 538 and 542.

[7]Grein, ed., *Bibliothek*, II, 146. For Grein's glosses on *holm* as *collis* ("hill") and *mons* ("mountain") and *holm-wudu* as *lignum montis*, see IV, 94–5. Kemble, "Additional Observations," 31–9; on the emendation to *holt-wudu*, see Kemble, *The Poetry of the Codex Vercellensis*, II, 89.

[8]Neidorf and Xu, "The Textual Criticism," 525–6; Dickins and Ross, eds., *The Dream of the Rood*, 31. Cook further cites two examples in medieval Latin liturgical songs where the Cross is said to be superior to all trees in the world. Cook, ed., *The Dream of the Rood*, 7 and 41.

[9]Bütow, ed., *Das altenglische Traumgesicht vom Kreuz*, 43 and 82.

[10]See, for example, Krapp, ed., *The Vercelli Book*, 64 and 131–2. Clayton retains *holm-wudu* but translates it as "the trees of the forest". Clayton, ed. and trans., *Old English Poems*, 166–7. For an interpretation of *holm-wudu* as "a kenning for ash", see Bintley, *Trees in the Religions*, 54 and 114–5.

arguing for a non-maritime interpretation as "hill-wood" or "protection-wood" based on linguistic evidence, and proposing possible associations with biblical images such as the *lignum vitae* ("tree of life") and the Gallows of Golgotha.[11]

Conversely, some scholars support both the manuscript reading *holm-wudu* and its maritime associations. R. E. Kaske contends that *holm-wudu* refers to the wood in Paradise surrounded by water.[12] Others believe this compound alludes to the *lignum crucis* ("wood of the Cross") and *lignum maris* ("wood of sea") metaphors in early Christian literary tradition.[13] As Heather Maring argues, the image of the Holy Cross above *holm-wudu* is reminiscent of a common Christian concept: the Cross is often compared to the mast of a ship because of the shape, materiality, and function.[14] However, these arguments have not been widely accepted despite the range of evidence offered. This article contends that the manuscript form *holm-wudu* should be retained, and examines the legitimacy of the manuscript reading from different angles.

In the first section, this article uncovers a connection between the image of the Cross and that of Mary in *The Dream of the Rood*, on the grounds of the widespread paronomasia on Mary as *stella maris* ("star of the sea").[15] Both images have close associations with spiritual seafaring in medieval Christian literature. The etymological interpretation of Mary as the guiding star for Christian seafarers is attested in various Old English texts, which may have been known to the poet of *The Dream of the Rood*. In the second section, this article investigates the contextual association of *holm-wudu* with other *holm-* and *-wudu* compounds denoting "ship", and argues that this unique *-wudu* compound shows the poet's interest in the theme of spiritual voyage. Finally, this article contends that by establishing a direct connection between the Cross and Mary, the poet creates a nautical scene in 90–4: Christians will safely sail towards the harbour of eternal joy, with Mary being their guiding Pole Star in sky, and the Holy Cross above their ships of life.

Mary, Star of the Sea

Several scholars have noticed the parallel between *holm-wudu* and Mary in the passage.[16] Yet the relationship between the Cross and Mary manifested in the comparison in *The Dream of the Rood* 90–4 may be more closely intertwined than previously acknowledged. This connection is reinforced by the widespread medieval concept of Mary as *stella maris*,

[11]Kelly and Quinn, *Stone, Skin, and Silver*, 46 and 88; Swanton, ed., *The Dream of the Rood*, 94 and 128; Huppé, ed. and trans., *The Web of Words*, 70 and 102; Stephens, *Runic Monuments*, I, 426 and 41. On Doomsday Book place-name *Homestreu*, see Berkhout, "*Holmwudu*," 430; Swanton, *The Dream of the Rood*, 128. See further, Gelling, *Place-names*, 215. For an opinion that *holm* and *helm* are interchangeable in 91a with *holm-wudu* being a deliberate pun on *helm-wudu* ("protection-wood" or "tree of refuge", also never attested in Old English corpus), see Pickford, "*Holmwudu*," 561–4.

[12]Kaske, "A Poem of the Cross," 67.

[13]Maring, "Two Ships Crossing," 242–4; McEntire, "The Devotional Context," 397–8; Berkhout, "*Holmwudu*," 431–3; On the seafaring motif in early Christian writing in general, see, for instance, Daniélou, "The Ship of the Church," 58–70; Rahner, "Odysseus at the Mast," esp. 341–53 and 371–86; Rahner, "Antenna Crucis III," 1–21.

[14]Maring, "Two Ships Crossing," 242. On a possible interpretation of *holm-wudu* as "mast", see, Dickins and Ross, *The Dream of the Rood*, 31; Marquardt, *Die altenglischen kenningar*, 229. On the mast-Cross comparison, see further, Daniélou, "The Ship of the Church," 66; Rahner, "Odysseus at the Mast," 371–88.

[15]The term *paronomasia* is defined by Frank as "the establishing of an etymological or pseudo-etymological relationship between two or more words". Frank, "Some Uses," 208. For Bede's definition in *De schematibus et tropis*, II.i.9, see Jones *et al.* eds., *Opera Didascalica*, 147–8.

[16]Ó Carragáin, "Vision Transfigured into Prayer," 308–11; Huppé, *The Web of Words*, 102.

that is, the star of the sea, who is the guardian of Christian seafarers in the sea of the world. The sacred etymology of Mary may have come from medieval Christian writers such as Jerome and Isidore of Seville, whose works enjoy wide currency in early medieval England.[17]

Jerome explains the Hebrew name of Mary as *stilla maris* ("a drop of the sea") in *Quaestiones hebraicae in libro Geneseos* ("Hebrew Questions on Genesis") and *Liber de Nominibus Hebraicis* ("Book on Hebrew Names").[18] A more common collocation *stella maris* is attested in some versions of Jerome's texts and in works of medieval Christian writers including Isidore of Seville, Bede, and Alcuin of York.[19] Both images, *stilla maris* ("a drop of the sea") and *stella maris* ("the star of the sea"), may derive from I Kings 18.41–45, where the symbol of hope is a small cloud rising from the sea to end the long period of drought.[20]

Isidore, for example, explains the name Mary as *inluminatrix, sive stella maris* ("enlightener, or star of the sea") in his *Etymologiae* ("Etymologies") VII.x.1.[21] Bede endorses this signification and writes *Maria autem Hebraice stella maris Syriace uero domina uocatur* ("But Mary is called 'the Star of the Sea' in Hebrew and indeed 'Lady' in Syriac") in his *In Lucae euangelium* ("On the Gospel of Luke") I.i.27.[22] In *Homily* I.3 which is dedicated to the Annunciation, Bede reminds his readers of the nautical connotation behind the name *stella maris*: it is a testimony to the exceptional merits (*meritis praecipuis*) of Mary, who shines like a distinguished star on the sky *inter fluctus saeculi labentis* ("among the waves of the passing world").[23] The allusion of Mary to the spiritual beacon of seafarers is evidently presented by the nautical diction in the passage.

Evidence in medieval liturgical hymns and antiphons also calls to mind a maritime association with sea and seafaring, including the popular eighth- or ninth- century antiphon *Ave Maris Stella*.[24] Mary is depicted as a heavenly guide of Christian sea-goers, a symbol of safe sea-voyage.[25] She is *maris stella* and *felix caeli porta* ("happy gate of heaven"), who is asked to prepare a safe voyage to her believers (*iter para tutum*).[26] Whilst *porta* ("gate") and *iter* ("journey") do not necessarily have nautical implications, the etymological name of Mary as *stella maris* hints at the idea of voyage in the sea. Alcuin of York, too, praises Mary as *lux et stella maris* ("light and the star of the sea") in *Carmina* 109.4, a four-line stanza composed for the Altar of Saint Mary in the abbey church of St Peter in Salzburg.[27] By venerating the Blessed Virgin Mary

[17]Thiel, *Grundlagen und Gestalt*, 351. On Jerome and Isidore as two of the four most read Latin patristic authors in early medieval England, see Lapidge, *The Anglo-Saxon Library*, 127 and 309–16.
[18]Lagarde, Morin, and Adriaen, eds., *Sancti Hieronymi Opera*, 76 and 137.
[19]Thomas, "Orm's Vernacular Latinity," 169–70; Thiel, *Grundlagen und Gestalt*, 351.
[20]Rudolf, "The Spiritual Islescape," 49; Clayton, *The Cult*, 94 and 248–53; Maas, "Virgin Mary," 464.
[21]Hawk, *Preaching Apocrypha*, 194. For the Latin text, see Lindsay, ed., *Isidori Hispalensis Episcopi*, I. On the reception of *Etymologiae* in early medieval England, see, for instance, Porter, "Isidore's *Etymologiae*," 10–30; Rusche, "Isidore's *Etymologiae*," 455.
[22]For the Latin text, see Hurst, ed., *Opera Exegetica 3*, 31. On the popularity of the cult of Mary in early medieval England, see further, Jones, "The Vernacular Theology," 1–16.
[23]For the Latin text, see Hurst and Fraipont, eds., *Opera Homiletica*, 15.
[24]See, for instance, Thomas, "Orm's Vernacular Latinity," 169–78; Clayton, *The Cult*, 94 and 248–53; Maas, "Virgin Mary," 464.
[25]Thompson, "The Virgin Mary," 250; Budwey, *Sing of Mary*, 28; Comaskey, "*Ave Maris Stella*," 930. On the wide currency of *Ave Maris Stella* in the Middle Ages, see Fassler, *Music in the Medieval West*, 3–10.
[26]The Latin text is taken from Brittain, ed., *The Penguin Book of Latin Verse*, 129–30.
[27]Dümmler, ed., *Alcuini Carmina*, 336.

throughout their earthly voyage, the faithful can hope to ascend to the celestial harbour and ultimately celebrate reunion with their saviour, Jesus Christ.

In vernacular English literature, the knowledge of Mary as "star of the sea" is further attested in the eleventh-century Old English version of the Latin *Gospel of Pseudo-Matthew* (hereafter *Pseudo-Matthew*).[28] The Old English *Pseudo-Matthew* appears much later than *The Dream of the Rood*, but other versions of the Latin original may have been in circulation in England since no later than the end of the ninth century.[29] The Old English version contains a homiletic prologue concerning the Nativity of Mary, which is not included in the original text. What is especially noteworthy about the prologue is that the author categorically states the knowledge of Mary as the "star of the sea", *nū is hyre nama gereht hlǣfdige oððe cwēn oððe sǣ-steorra* ("Now her name is interpreted as Lady or Queen or Sea-star"),[30] before defining the meaning of *sǣ-steorra* ("sea-star", "star of the sea") as the guardian of seafarers:

> **Sǣ-steorra** / hēo is gecweden forðan þe se **sǣ-steorra** on niht gecȳþeð **scyp-liðendum mannum** hwȳder bið ēast and west, hwȳder sūð and norð. Swā þonne wearð þurh ðā halgan fǣmnan Sancta Marian gecȳþed se **rihte sīð-fæt** tō ðām **ēcan life** þām ðe lange ǣr sǣton on þēostrum and on dēaþes scūan and on þām **unstillum ȳðum þǣre sǣ þises middan-eardes**.
>
> (She is called the Star of the Sea, because the star of the sea informs sea-faring men of where east and west are, where south and north. So in the same way through the Holy Virgin Mary, the right journey to that eternal life was shown to those who previously sat in darkness for long and in the shadow of death and in those restless waves of the sea of this middle-earth.)

Mary is not only the Pole Star that guides seafarers, but also a spiritual beacon that illuminates the correct path towards *ēcan life* ("eternal life") for Christian believers.[31] The nautical imagery in this passage is straight-forwardly reminiscent of traditional Christian ship symbolism. For the seafaring souls struggling in their life-voyage amidst the sea of the earthly ordeals, it is Mary who guarantees successful spiritual salvation.[32]

Evidently, the compound *sǣ-steorra* in the homiletic prologue to the Old English *Pseudo-Matthew* is a calque on the Latin *stella maris*, exclusively denoting Mary.[33] The *DOE Corpus* shows that *sǣ-steorra* occurs in the Old English *Pseudo-Matthew* and an Old English interlinear gloss of *Hymn 66*, *Item Ymnus* (a version of the Latin *Ave Maris Stella*) from the Durham Hymnal in an eleventh-century manuscript, where the glossator gives *hal sy þū sǣ-steorra* ("hail to you, star-of-the-sea") for the Latin *ave, maris stella* ("hail, star of the sea").[34] Moreover, viewed in a wider perspective, the phrase *steorra sǣ* ("star of the sea") is attested in another interlinear gloss of the Latin *Ave Maris Stella* in an eleventh-century manuscript, where the Old English glossator

[28]The text is preserved in three manuscripts: Oxford, Bodleian Library, MS Hatton 114; Cambridge, Corpus Christi College, MS 367, Part II; and Oxford, Bodleian Library, MS Bodley 343.

[29]On dating of the Latin text (550 to 700) and the Old English version (early eleventh century), see Clayton, *The Apocryphal Gospels*, 18 and 138–9.

[30]The Old English text is taken from Clayton, *The Apocryphal Gospels*, 164. For a general introduction to the prologue, see 85 and 136–9. For a comparison between the J text and N text of the prologue, see Assmann, ed., *Angelsächsische Homilien*, 117.

[31]On the association between *stella maris* and the North Star, see further, Hartley, "Astronomical Names," 515–16.

[32]Budwey, *Sing of Mary*, 28–9; Rudolf, "The Spiritual Islescape," 49–50.

[33]Clayton, *The Apocryphal Gospels*, 139 and 196.

[34]The glossed text is preserved in Canterbury, Durham, Cathedral Library, B. III. 32. Milfull, *The Hymns*, vii. For the text and a commentary, see Milfull, *The Hymns*, 271–4.

generally uses the same phraseology as that of the Durham Hymnal.[35] This Marian hymn enjoyed widespread circulation in early medieval England, and was performed in varied liturgical settings.[36]

The aforementioned examples all testify that since no later than the age of Bede, this appellation of Mary signifying *stella maris* was familiar in early medieval England. As scholars have argued that the poet of *The Dream of the Rood* is well versed in Latin liturgical hymns, it is very likely that the poet would have been acquainted with the common designation of Mary as "star of the sea".[37]

Mary's central position in nautical discourse should be understood in the light of the traditional patristic image of Christ as the steersman.[38] This image appears in Old English texts such as *Andreas*, *Blicking Homily* XVIII, and the Old English *Boethius*.[39] Perhaps motivated by a similar interest in accentuating Christ as the holy skipper, the translator of the Old English *Boethius* adds a passage to eulogise Christ as the sole *staðol-fæst wealdend and stīora and steor-rōðer and helma* ("stead-fast ruler, and pilot, and rudder, and helm") in *Prose 22*, explaining that Christ rightfully maintains the order of the world *swā swā gōd stīora ānum scipe* ("just like a good pilot [controls] a ship").[40] In addition, surviving Old English and Latin texts provide powerful proof that their authors tend to add such maritime dimension in their accounts of Christ and his mother Mary: if Christ is the holy steersman of one's ship of life, so Mary is a Pole Star on high, the guarantor of safe voyage for the floating soul.[41]

Many Old English authors have a shared interest in interpreting or making onomastic puns on the etymological meanings of other personal names, especially those concerning biblical figures: for example, Andreas equals "virility", Daniel "judgement of God", and Elene "courage".[42] One of the most typical cases is the *Daniel*-poet's frequent allusion to Daniel as *iudicium Dei* ("judgement of God"), where the poet uses *Dryhtnes dōmas* ("judgement of God") in *Daniel* 32a and 744a, and puts the name Daniel and its etymological meaning *dom* in the same line in 150a, 163, 531, 547a, 654, and 661a. As the poet of *The Dream of the Rood* frequently alludes to other Old English poems, he (or she) may be well versed in such common practice of onomastic puns in the vernacular tradition.[43] In this sense, the nautical image of the Holy Cross above all *holm-wudu* in 91a could

[35]London, British Library Cotton MS Julius A VI. For the text, see Gneuss, *Hymnar und Hymnen*, 349–50.

[36]Thompson, "The Virgin Mary," 250; Milfull, *The Hymns*, 273. On the influence of medieval Latin liturgical texts on *The Dream of the Rood*, see Ó Carragáin, "Vision Transfigured into Prayer," esp. 311, 321–2, 322–4, and 330–1.

[37]Ó Carragáin, "Vision Transfigured into Prayer," 310–28.

[38]North and Bintley, eds., *Andreas*, 255–6; Daniélou, "The Ship of the Church," 59–60; Rahner, "Odysseus at the Mast," 344, 348, and 373–75. For the same image in early Christian art, see, for instance, Stuhlfauth, "Das Schiff," esp. 133–4.

[39]Christ the skipper is also hinted at *Christ B* 858b–863. For a recent argument that Christ is depicted as a king-like skipper in *Andreas* modelled on King Alfred, see North, "King Alfred," esp. 443–8. On the theme of steering the ship of the mind and the portrayal of King Alfred as a skilled steersman in Alfredian narrative, see further, Ponirakis, "Steering the Ship," esp. 55 and 60–7.

[40]Reference to the text is from Godden and Irvine, eds. and trans., *The Old English Boethius*, I, 485. See further, Gregory the Great, *Regula Pastoralis* 3.32 in Judic, Rommel, and Morel, eds. and trans., *Règle pastorale*, II, 492, where he warns about the danger of a *gubernator* ("pilot") losing the *clauus* ("rudder") which is used *ad regendam nauem corporis* ("to steer ship of the body") in the sea.

[41]*B-T*, **s.v.** "sǣ-steorra".

[42]Frank, "Some Uses," 212–14, 216–17, 220–1, 222–3; Robinson, "The Significance," esp. 16–35; Robinson, "Some Uses," esp. 161–5. For Elene as *ellen* ("courage", "valour"), see McBrine, "The Journey Motif," 314.

[43]On the association between *Daniel* and *The Dream of the Rood*, see Orchard, "Cross-References," 27–8. On paronomasia in early biblical poems such as *Genesis A* and *B* and *Exodus*, see Frank, "Some Uses," 211–18, 221–2, and 225. On other collocations of word-play in *Daniel*, see 219–21 and 225.

enable the name Mary in 92b to be seamlessly integrated into the poet's intricately designed portrayal of a safe spiritual voyage in the passage.

The Making and Unmaking of Holm-wudu

The case for retaining the manuscript reading *holm-wudu* in the *Dream of the Rood* is further bolstered when the evidence for *holm-* and *-wudu* compounds denoting "ship" in Old English poetry is taking into consideration. In patristic tradition, the Cross is often compared to the mast of a ship, whilst in the ecclesiastical culture in early medieval England, the ship itself is often likened to the Cross.[44] The ship, especially in the case of Noah's Ark, appears in insular manuscript illustrations and on physical crosses, symbolising the Holy Cross.[45] Though not adopting the form of a *-wudu* compound, the ship-Cross comparison is not uncommon in Old English literary tradition and can be found in early poems such as *Exodus*.[46]

The simplex *holm* is mostly preserved in poetic texts (forty out of forty-five recorded instances). Among all the poetic compounds with *holm* as the first element, *holm-wudu* is not the only compound that refers to "ship". Another compound for "ship", *holm-ærn* ("sea-house", specifically denoting Noah's Ark), appears once in the corpus, in the early poem *Genesis A* 1422b.[47] The poet of *Genesis A* perceives a unique analogy between Noah's Ark and earthbound architectures such as buildings and halls. In this poetic coinage for Noah's Ark as a "sea-house", the poet creates a pattern of simplexes for "sea" as the first element and those for "house" or "hall" as the second element, which perfectly matches the biblical story. The giant vessel, which shelters Noah, his family, and the chosen animals for more than a year on the sea, serves as a real house to them.

In Old English poems such as *Beowulf* (216b, 298a, and 1919a), the simplex *wudu* ("wood", "tree", "ship") itself could already denote "ship".[48] The materiality of ships made of different kinds of wood naturally invites Old English poets to designate "ship" as "wood" in their poetic composition. It is then a matter of course to describe a ship, which is floating on the sea, as a "wood in the sea". Invariably, all the *-wudu* compounds meaning "ship" contain a first element meaning "water" or "sea" and have highly restricted distributions. They appear only in a small range of interrelated texts: *brim-wudu* ("sea-wood") in *Elene* 244b and *Guthlac B* 1331b, twice; *flōd-wudu* ("flood-wood") in *Christ B* 853a, once; *sǣ-wudu* ("sea-wood") in *Beowulf* 226a, once; and *sund-wudu* ("sea-wood") in *Beowulf* 208a and 1906b and *Christ B* 677b, three times. In terms of dating, *Beowulf* and *The Dream of the Rood* are probably the earliest among the five poems.[49] While the influence of *Beowulf* upon Cynewulf's works is acknowledged

[44]Maring, "Two Ships Crossing," 242–3.
[45]McEntire, "The Devotional Context," 397–8.
[46]On the ship-Cross comparison in *Exodus*, see Karkov, *Text and Picture*, 117; Lucas, "Old English Christian Poetry," 195–202 and 205. On an early date for *Exodus*, see Fulk, *A History*, 3, 62–3, 64, 195–6, 348, and 391–2.
[47]On an early date for *Genesis A*, see for instance, Fulk, *A History*, 3, 23, 62, 64, 248, 348–9, and 390–2.
[48]See further, Thier, *Old English Sea Terms*, 145–6. *Word-hord* states: "the sense 'ship' is entirely confined to verse".
[49]There had been disagreements on the exact dating of Old English poems, but today there is consensus among scholars, especially philologists, about the general chronology of surviving texts. See, for example, Fulk, *A History*, 61, 348–9, and 393–418. For varied scholarly opinions concerning the composition period of *Beowulf*, see, for instance, Neidorf, ed., *The Dating of Beowulf*; and Chase, ed., *The Dating of Beowulf*. On the dating of *The Dream of the Rood*, see Ó Carragáin, "Vision Transfigured into Prayer," 308, 316, and 331.

by previous scholars, Andy Orchard argues that *The Dream of the Rood* is also a direct source and an inspiration for Cynewulf, especially for his *Elene*.[50] The nautical theme indicated by the "sea-wood" image in *The Dream of the Rood* also echoes other texts with journey motif in the Vercelli Book manuscript, like Cynewulf's *Elene* and *The Fates of the Apostles*, *Andreas*, *Soul and Body I*, and *Homiletic Fragment I*.[51]

The "sea-wood" (*sǣ-wudu* and *sund-wudu*) in *Beowulf* refers to Beowulf's ship, which carries him and his thanes to the land of the Danes.[52] In the arrival and departure passages of Beowulf's round trip to Denmark (*Beowulf* 194–229 and 1888–1924) are the two "sea-wood" terms, *sǣ-wudu* 226a and *sund-wudu* in 208a and 1906b, functioning mainly both as a poetic strategy of varying the poetic language for "ship" and also as a structural device signalling the different stages of the plot.[53] By contrast, while the image of "sea-wood" in *Beowulf* represents the physical quality of Beowulf's ship, it often convey metaphorical meanings centred around the idea of a salvific voyage in later texts.

Two terms, *flōd-wudu* and *sund-wudu*, pertain to the ship of life of every Christian in Cynewulf's signed poem *Christ B*, a vehicle towards spiritual salvation.[54] Cynewulf elucidates this idea of a liminal, post-mortem journey from earthly dwelling to heavenly harbour of salvation at the end of *Christ B* (850–866).[55] The poet asks the audience to consider *gæstes wlite* ("the beauty of the soul" in 848a), and he describes an ideal scene of the souls of Christians travelling on ships *geond þās wācan weorold* ("throughout this feeble world" in 855a). At the end of the voyage the souls would reach the heavenly harbour (*hȳþ* in 859b and 864a), and find salvation (*hǣlu* in 859a) and hope (*hyht* in 864b). By employing rich nautical vocabulary in the passage, including the "sea-wood", *flōd-wudu* in 853a, Cynewulf emphasises the image of the ship of life as a God-given gift (*gyfu* in 860b).[56]

In another signed poem of Cynewulf, *Elene*, *brim-wudu* refers to the ship of Elene (Saint Helena), mother of Constantine the Great. Elene and her army embark on a sea-voyage to find the True Cross, where the animated "sea-wood" hastens (*snyrian* in 244b), plays (*plegan* in 245b), advances (*wadan* in 246a), and bursts forth through the sea (*brecan ofer bæð-weg* in 244a), like a horse in motion.[57] Cynewulf develops the metaphorical dimension of the "sea-wood" image to underscore an evangelic sense behind the ship of Elene: the vehicle brings Christian faith and salvation to Jerusalem.[58]

In the Cynewulfian poem *Guthlac B*, the same "sea-wood" compound *brim-wudu* (which is employed by Cynewulf in *Elene*) denotes the boat of Beccel, Saint Guthlac's

[50]Orchard, "Cross-References," 229 and 248–51. On Cynewulf's borrowing from *Beowulf*, see Orchard, "Alcuin and Cynewulf," 333–8; Leneghan, "The Departure of The Hero," 107–20; Schaar, *Critical Studies*, 239–51; Sarrazin, *Beowulf-Studien*, 108–36; Sarrazin, "*Beowulf* und Kynewulf," 515–50. Earlier studies tend to attribute *The Dream of the Rood* to Cynewulf. See further, Bjork, ed. and trans., *Cynewulf*, xi; Anderson, *Cynewulf*, 20–2; Schaar, *Critical Studies*, 108–11, 113–14, 135, 304, and 326.

[51]McBrine, "The Journey Motif," 298 and 317.

[52]Fulk, Bjork, and Niles, eds., *Klaeber's Beowulf*, 9–10 and 64.

[53]On the *Beowulf*-poet's habit of using repetition and variation, see, for example, Robinson, *Beowulf*, esp. 60–6. On Beowulf's sea-voyages' functions in the envelop pattern or ring structure, see, for instance, Niles, "Ring Composition," 930; Tonsfeldt, "Ring Structure," 445; Hieatt, "Envelope Patterns," 256, 258, 260 and 263.

[54]See also, Bjork, *Cynewulf*, 18 and 30; Hill, "The Anchor of Hope," 289–92.

[55]Bjork, *Cynewulf*, 30.

[56]Hill, "The Anchor of Hope," 289–92.

[57]Bjork, *Cynewulf*, 158. On *brecan ofer bæð-weg* in *Elene* and *Andreas*, see Powell, *Verbal Parallels*, 218–19.

[58]On the Vercelli Book compiler's interests in collecting texts with homiletic and eschatological themes in the manuscript, see Leneghan, "Teaching the Teachers," 627–32 and 650–3; Ó Carragáin, "How Did the Vercelli Collector," esp. 67–78 and 98.

servant, who left the marshy Crowland to deliver the sad news of Guthlac's death to the saint's sister.[59] The image of the boat in *Guthlac B* takes on a different connotation: it reflects a universal, figurative image of the ship of one's soul.[60] The limited textual distribution of the *-wudu* compounds may well indicate both intentional borrowing in later works and a shared interest in the Christian concept of life-voyage in these religious poems.

When approached in this context, retaining the manuscript form *holm-wudu* in *The Dream of the Rood* 91a has the advantage of evoking the theme of "salvation through life-journey" (135b–144a).[61] Elsewhere in the poem, the poet purposefully underscores Christ's life and mission as a *sīþ-fæt* ("journey", "expedition" in 150b), a cosmic voyage transcending the boundaries between the spiritual and the material, between heaven, earth, and hell (150–6).[62] Through the mouth of the dreamer, the poet expresses his (or her) yearning for a posthumous voyage of salvation, a strong eagerness to ascend towards heaven at the end of the earthly life, a trans-dimensional journey to be achieved by the ferry of the Cross (131b–144a).[63] While no diction for "ship" is explicitly mentioned in the passage, the poet, by using verbs as *gefetian* ("bring", "fetch" in 138a), *gebringan* ("bring" in 139a), and *asettan* ("set", "place" in 142a) to describe the motion of the animated Cross, tends to regard the Cross as a vehicle, a ship-like transportation. The Cross fetches Christian believers, brings them to heaven, and places them among other joyful souls in the eternal homeland, just like a ship fetches its passengers and conveys them to another land.[64]

Furthermore, the verb *gestīgan* ("set out") used in the poem, especially in 41a (when Christ mounts the Cross during the Crucifixion) and 104a (the Ascension), is almost invariably linked with ships in the Old English corpus.[65] As Maring points out, this verb often refers to actions of mounting or climbing on a ship in both prose and verse texts, such as *Beowulf* 210b–13a, *Andreas* 220–3b and 897–9, Ælfric's *Homilies*, and the Old English *Life of Saint Mary of Egypt*.[66] Likewise, such an implication for a spiritual

[59]Guthlac was said to became a hermit in the fens of Crowland. The vehicle is more of a boat, though the diction used by the poet is typical of a sea-voyage. Roberts, ed., *The Guthlac Poems*, 56–7. For the text, see Bjork, *Cynewulf*, 70. On arguments proposing Cynewulf as the author of *Guthlac B*, see page xi; Orchard, "Both Style and Substance," 294–6; Fulk, "Cynewulf," 5–6; Roberts, *The Guthlac Poems*, 56–62. On parallels between *Guthlac B* and Cynewulf's signed poems, see Orchard, *The Craft and Cunning*, 274–8; Orchard, "Both Style and Substance," 281–5.

[60]On early Church fathers' mentioning of the ship of one's soul, see Rahner, "Odysseus at the Mast," 349–53.

[61]On the dreamer's hope for both a bodily and spiritual voyage towards heaven implied by the verbs in the passage, see Ó Carragáin, "Vision Transfigured into Prayer," 330.

[62]On Christ's life from Incarnation to Ascension as a unified cosmic expedition in *The Dream of the Rood*, see Ó Carragáin, "Vision Transfigured into Prayer," 321–5. On the common theme of life-voyage in all poems in the Vercelli Book, see McBrine, "The Journey Motif"; see esp. 303, 310 and 314 on *sīþ-fæt*.

[63]On the common theme of spiritual voyage of souls after death in Old English poetry, see Soper, *The Life Course*, 40–1, 126, 128, 130, and 188.

[64]While *gefetian* means "fetch" in *The Dream of the Rood* 138a, when collocating with *sīþ* ("journey", "voyage") in poetry, it means "make a journey", "make a voyage", like *sīð* and *aseted* in *Elene* 996–7. *DOE*, **s.v.** "*ge·feccan*, *ge·fecgan*, *ge·fetian*". Note that this collocation specifically refers to a sea-voyage in *Elene*: the messengers told Constantine the Great that the *sige-cwēn* ("victory-queen") Elene and her thegns made a safe voyage *ofer swan-rāde* ("across the swan-road") into *Crēca land* ("the Greek people's land").

[65]By using terms and expressions like *gestīgan*, the poet establishes parallels between the Crucifixion narration in 28–77 and the arrival or departure scenes of heroes' sea-voyages in other Old English poems like *Beowulf*. Maring, "Two Ships Crossing," 244–52. On the functions and importance of seafaring passages in *Beowulf*, see, for example, Ramsey, "The Sea Voyages," esp. 55 and 57–9. On a theory of 1–77 as the original text of *The Dream of the Rood* and 78–156 added by a later author, see Neidorf, "The Composite Authorship," esp. 67–70.

[66]Maring, "Two Ships Crossing," 249–50. For examples in Ælfric's *Homilies* and in the *Life of Saint Mary of Egypt*, see Magennis, ed., *The Old English Life*, 84; Godden, ed., *Ælfric's Catholic Homilies*, 113, 217, and 223.

voyage towards the heavenly kingdom suggested by the aforementioned verbs in *The Dream of the Rood* provides further support for retaining the manuscript reading *holm-wudu* in 91a as a compound denoting "ship", echoing the well-known image of *navis crucis* ("ship of the Cross") or *lignum maris* ("wood of the sea") in the Christian literary tradition.[67]

Indeed, it might be argued that various elements of nautical imagery are deeply embedded within *The Dream of the Rood*. The poet lays emphasis on the theme of life-journey by inserting phraseology with aquatic or navigational connotations and by drawing from typical sea-voyage scenes found in other poems.[68] The poet repeatedly puns on polysemic or homographic words like *swǣtan* ("sweat" or "bleed" in 20a, referring to either blood or water, both of which run from Christ's side-wound in John 19:34) and *stefn* ("stem" in 30a and "voice" 71b, primarily emphasising a "speaking tree" in the poem; the same word-form could also mean "prow" in other poems), and phrases such as *stēame bedrifenne* ("drenched in steam" or "drenched in blood" in 62a, depicting the Cross during Christ's Passion).[69] The homonymic *stefn* appears twice in the poem, in two biblical scenes central to salvation of human. It signifies the root of the Holy Cross in 30a (when the personified Cross says it was cut down from a *holt* "wood" and taken away from its *stefn* "root"), and the mourning of the crowd under the Cross in 71b (during the Lamentation).[70] With *holm-wudu* in 91a consolidating the image of the Cross honoured above all "wood-of-the-sea", the word-form *stefn* subtly refers to the wooden material of the Cross.

Conclusion

This article has presented new evidence for retaining the manuscript form *holm-wudu* in 91a which, if accepted, has the potential to contribute to a more coherent reading of the theological argument of *The Dream of the Rood*. Accepting this reading, we can see how the Cross-Mary comparison in 90–4 thematically clarifies the significance of spiritual salvation in *The Dream of the Rood*. Steeped in Christian symbolism and vernacular literature, the poet intelligently exploits existing connections between Mary and the Cross. Both *holm-wudu* and the name Mary point to a recognisable maritime reference, associated with the idea of salvation through voyage for individual Christians on the ship of life or for the Christian Church. The ultimate goal of salvation is to reach the heavenly harbour by prudently steering one's ship of life (91a). This goal is achieved through the help of three heavenly beings, indicated by the poet with paronomasia in the passage: Jesus Christ (91b), who is the divine steersman, the guardian of heaven, and the stern judge; his mother Mary (92b), the sea-star on high; and the Holy Cross (90a), the sacred wood towering over the mast of the wood in the sea, the salvific ship of the soul.

[67]McEntire, "The Devotional Context," 397–8; Berkhout, "*Holmwudu*," 431–33. The term nave (of a church) derives from the Latin *navis* ("ship"). Cram, "Nave," 724.

[68]On the poet's apparently deliberate wordplay, especially homographs and homophones in *The Dream of the Rood*, see Orchard, "Cross-References," 229–30 and 237.

[69]*Word-hord* gives *stefn* m. "prow", *stefn*[2] n. "root", "stem", and *stefn*[3] f. "voice"; and *swǣtan I* "sweat", "bleed". *B-T*, **s.v.** "*stefn*"; "*swǣtan*". On the dual meaning of *swǣtan*, see Clayton, *Old English Poems*, 378; Ó Carragáin, "Vision Transfigured into Prayer," 327. On *stēame bedrifenne*, see the same page in Ó Carragáin. On homographs *stefn*, see Orchard, "Cross-References," 229.

[70]On *stefn* in 71b, see Swanton, *The Dream of the Rood*, 129.

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